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Original Page: 251**Culture (OWC):** [San \(FX10\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Southern Africa**Field Date:** 1950-1961**Coverage Date:** 1950-1961**Place Coverage:** Nyae Nyae Region, Namibia And Botswana**Section Title(S):** A SPEAKING AVOIDANCE

Customarily a married son or daughter settles next to the parents, their fires and shelters only a few feet apart. They often build their shelters so that these are actually leaning on each other.

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The speaking avoidance under these circumstances does not impose excessive inconvenience. Both families overhear each other's conversations, and if, say, a man wants his son-in-law to know something, he simply says it to his wife or his daughter loudly enough for the son-in-law to hear. Unless one were informed one might not know that they were practicing a speaking avoidance.

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The interactions of people who accord each other reserved behavior are not constrained in any way except in the avoidance of joking and the practice of the other avoidances just described. The !Kung build their shelters and place their family fires close together, they hunt, gather, fetch water and wood, make artifacts, sing, dance, share food, and exchange gifts with the people they "respect"—with whom they are reserved—as readily and freely as with people they do not "respect" and with whom they may joke.

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